

Exodus 19:1-8 The Forming of a Holy Nation

Introduction:

Exposition:

One of those sermons where there is a disproportionate amount of instruction/teaching if we are to properly relate to this passage (you may want to take notes on this one)

I. Context:

Chapters 1-18: The accomplishment of God's salvation for a chosen people in continuity with promises past!

- A. We have seen how Exodus is the "sequel" to Genesis—even as the promises given to Adam through the patriarchs is clearly seen as being fulfilled, at least in one level, in the history surrounding the Exodus.
- B. Much of the history has been told with a view toward preparing God's chosen people for the establishment of a New Nation under a Priestly, Kingly and Prophet tradition handed down by God through Moses. Already, we have seen for instance the establishment of a priestly (altar) and kingly (government by elders) institution as by the advice of Jethro to Moses for instance in Chapt. 18, even as these institutions preview the institutions that would eventually be canonized as under the Mosaic law. (Notice our passage begins with the assembling of the elders as representing the whole of Israel)
- C. The history is told with a particular view toward the intended inclusion of the nations as per the promise made with Abraham, as for instance was the focus of Chapter 18 and the Mose's reunion with Jethro—even as Jethro was representative of a Gentile.

Chapters 19-24—The establishment of a holy and priestly nation under the Old Covenant law
The Lord had liberated Israel from bondage in Egypt, but now He will adopt the nation into a special relationship with Himself. Constable

In the formation of a new people, God would therefore establish them upon his word, sacraments and government—e.g. upon the prophetic, priestly and kingly institutions, even as these institutions are "instituted" in the Mosaic law..

II. Exodus 19:1-6

Ex. 3:12

He said, "I will be with you; and this shall be the sign for you that it is I who sent you: when you have brought the people out of Egypt, you shall worship God on this mountain."

Vs. 1: About three months after they had left Egypt, in May-June, following the great redemption of Israel from Egypt, the Israelites arrived at the base of Mt.

This observation in vs. 1 ties the promise made by God in Ex.3:12 to the fulfillment of that promise.

Mose's journey has come full circle—he once met with God on Mt. Horeb in chapter 3, and he has now returned to Him with the recently redeemed Israelites.

The sum effect of this full circle—as by the deliverance transacted by God through Moses, is that Israel, once the possession of Egypt “has been transformed into a worshipping people of God.” (Dumbrell quoted by Peter Enns)

The specific location of biblical Mt. Sinai continues to be uncertain and will not concern us here.. What we do not is that the fledgling new nation will stay at Mt. Sinai for 11 months (Num. 10:11) and will take the writer 59 chapters to describe (e.g. the record of their experiences at Mt Sinai continues through Numbers 10:10), such as then to accentuate the importance of this portion of Israel history.

And it concerns the general meaning of this episode at Mt.Sinai that our passage concerns itself!

Vs. 1-2—The arrival of Moses with the Israelites and setting up camp

vs. 3-6, beginning with Moses ascent up the mountain of God, THE FIRST OF MANY SUCH TRIPs

Many scholars consider verses 3-6, and this 1st trip of Moses up the mountain of God to be at the very heart of the Pentateuch because it contains the classic expression of the nature and purpose of the theocratic covenant that God made with Israel as given to MOSES.

“Without doubt Exodus 19:4-6 is the most theologically significant text in the book of Exodus, for it is the linchpin between the patriarchal promises of the sonship of Israel and the Sinaitic Covenant whereby Israel became the servant nation of Yahweh.”

Constable quoting Merrill, “A Theology . . .,” p. 32. Cf. William J. Dumbrell, *Covenant and Creation*, pp. 80-81.

We see then that the words are given not just to Moses, but to the “house of Jacob” e.g the sons of Israel” (v. 3).³¹²

I.e. Moses is the prophetic conduit between God and God’s people

IF then the first stage of Mose’s ministry was to be as a mediatorial savior, the second is to be as a mediatorial prophet and law giver..

As then turning to our passage itself-- 3 important observations:

#1: “Remember” (vs. 4)—whatever else is going to be said, it’s credibility is grounded in God’s actions past! They are to think back as to what God has already done, as then a basis for trusting God into the future and as a basis for their obedience to God’s rightful place as Lord of the newly formed OC church!

Remember what? “on eagles wings”

A memorable phrase that depicts Israel being carried as “on eagles wings.”

Elsewhere in the OT, eagles are depicted in two ways:

a) As birds that are particularly noted for their care for the young/weak.

“The image of the eagle [v. 4] is based on the fact that the eagle, when its offspring learns [*sic*] to fly, will catch them on its wings when they fall.”

So then, Dt. 32:9-11

Deut. 32:10

He sustained him in a desert land,
in a howling wilderness waste;

he shielded him, cared for him,
 guarded him as the apple of his eye.
11 As an eagle stirs up its nest,
 and hovers over its young;
 as it spreads its wings, takes them up,
 and bears them aloft on its pinions,

God's deliverance of Israel is therefore compared to "an eagle swooping down to hover over its young and carrying them off to safety" (Enns)

b) Eagles are also fierce birds of prey.. as in Dt. 29:49 (se Jer.4:13, 48:40ff, 49:22)

Jer.13 Look! He comes up like clouds,
 his chariots like the whirlwind;
 his horses are swifter than eagles—
 woe to us, for we are ruined!

As then to depict God's fury against Egypt perhaps

IN both ways therefore Israel is to remember the great compassion and power of God on their behalf in saving them from their enslavement which then anticipates God's establishing them in the promises made to the patriarchs concerning a great nation in a promises land!

#2—The Israelites, as a result of remembering are given a Conditional promise:

vs. 5: "Now... if... then...

Thus, two part: condition (if) and the subsequent conditional promise.

a) Condition:

וְעַתָּה אִם-שָׁמַעַתְּ תִשְׁמָעוּ בְּקוֹלִי ("Now, therefore, IF you hear such as to obey my voice...")

E.g. the Hebrew word twice used is "shama" or "to hear" but used here clearly as to mean "hear" as in to "believe and obey"

Notice: The Hebrew wd trans. "obey" combines two grammatical uses of the same word to bring emphasis to the conditions that are set forth.. (inf. "to hear" and imper

b) Promise:

God's promise to Israel here (vv. 5-6) went beyond what He had promised Abraham. *If* Israel would be obedient to God, He would do three things for the nation (cf. Josh. 24:15).

1. Israel was to become God's special treasure (v. 5). This means that Israel would enjoy a unique relationship with God compared with all other nations.

Deut. 7:6

For you are a people holy to the LORD your God; the LORD your God has chosen you out of all the peoples on earth to be his people, his **treasured possession**.

Deut. 14:2

For you are a people holy to the LORD your God; it is you the LORD has chosen out of all the peoples on earth to be his people, his **treasured possession**.

Deut. 26:18

Today the LORD has obtained your agreement: to be his **treasured** people, as he promised you, and to keep his commandments;

2. Israel was to become a kingdom of priests (v. 6). A priest stands between God and humankind. Israel could become a nation of mediators standing between God and the other nations responsible for bringing them to God and God to them

E.g. In this sense the nation was to be missional—it was to be evangelistic in so far as it mediated between sinful humanity and a Holy, albeit gracious, God! Such a “kingdom of priests” would bring forth the gospel according to Moses as to the grace of God acting through her sacrificial system focused in the temple.

Again, notice how Paul understands “priestly” in an evangelistic sense in

Rom. 15:16

to be a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles in the **priestly** service of the gospel of God, so that the offering of the Gentiles may be acceptable, sanctified by the Holy Spirit.

3. Israel was to become a holy nation (v. 6). Holy means set apart and therefore different. E.g. their worship, their code of ethics, their core values—all was to be other worldly for the glory of God... even as this was viewed as complementary to their call to be evangelistic priests to the nations! The Israelites would become different from other peoples because they would devote themselves to God and separate from sin and defilement as they obeyed the law of God.

This new priestly nation would be “royal” in so far as it depicted God’s rule and government in the world...

In short, Israel could have become a testimony to the whole world of how glorious it can be to live under the government of God. Israel would be as God’s special treasured people!

Clearly however, these promises would have been interpreted as attached to the promises already given as to prosper in a promised land as well. Note the language—“the whole earth is mine” which speaks to God’s sovereignty and perhaps too God’s previous promise to give Israel a piece of the earth if you will... Eg. We cannot forget the continuity with patriarchal history—and especially the promise made to Moses in the beginning that

Ex. 3:7

Then the LORD said, “I have observed the misery of my people who are in Egypt; I have heard their cry on account of their taskmasters. Indeed, I know their sufferings, **8** and I have come down to deliver them from the Egyptians, and to bring them up out of that land to a good and broad land, **a land flowing with milk and honey,**

#3: Israel’s Response: Exodus 19:7-15

8 *The people all answered as one: “Everything that the LORD has spoken we will do.”*

Given what God has done for them and the things they are to remember. And given the promises God is here attaching to the condition of their obedience. They appreciated what God had done for them... they wanted what God offered them.

"Everything that the LORD has spoken we will do."

The reaction of the Israelites to God's promises was understandably positive.

And does it sound familiar?

Can't we relate—even if such conditions are fabricated in our own minds as to evoke similar expressions of commitment?

God—if you will get me into this school, help me with this test, get my children out of this mess, save my marriage.... I will do ANYTHING you want?

Hmmmmmm.....

Excursus: "TIME OUT"

So, herein we feel a question forming--- Did Israel ever achieve the obedience they promised such as to gain the promised God is offering?

Are we to take from this that God's love is conditional?

Even more haunting—was God setting them up for failure?

Clearly, they overestimated their own ability to keep the covenant, and they underestimated God's standards for them. This twin error is traceable to a failure to appreciate their own sinfulness and God's holiness. The conditional aspect of *The Mosaic Law would teach them to appreciate both.*

Israel would be as a tarnished treasure and would never really enjoy much of the promised land—even as by the time we reach the end of the OT—Israel is scattered throughout the world—under all sorts of unfriendly political regimes—only a remnant regathered back into the area of Jerusalem.

Perhaps then their response also points us to the nature of this covenant fundamentally, in contrast to the promise offered to Abraham even

e.g.

Notice:

If we compare the covenant made in Genesis 15 with the covenant made in Exodus 24. Whereas in Genesis 15, God takes the vows of obedience, here in Exodus 19 (see also Ex. 24), the people take the vows. The "blood" of sacrifice looks back to the Abraham and even Adam as to God's promise of grace, whereas the conditional aspects of this covenant and the vows of the people look to that aspect that is temporal as related to land and ethnic nation and is akin to the probationary aspects of the law once given to Adam in Eden.

Putting all of this into redemptive history:

What's going on here?—a promise as attached to a condition of obedience... !

And yet, many have tried to minimize the conditionality of this promise as to fit a New Covenant understanding of salvation by grace—as then reflected throughout the Old.

Irons:

Study of the literature of the classic Reformed covenant theologians shows that there

were two historic positions within mainstream Reformed covenant theology on the subject of the Mosaic Covenant. The first position is that the Mosaic Covenant is essentially a gracious covenant administered in a legal manner. The second, quite widespread opinion is that the Mosaic Covenant is essentially a republication of the Adamic covenant of works. Both historic Reformed positions hold that there is a works aspect in the Mosaic administration, focused primarily on the Law's function as a pedagogue to lead Israel to Christ.

Example: Peter Enns— concerning vs. 5-6: “That Israel’s faithfulness to the covenant is required should in no way be understood to mean that Israel worked for her salvation in the Old Testament... this entire scene at the mountain and the subsequent laws are predicated on vs. 4, what God has done... The Israelites are not to keep the law in order for God to save them. They have already been saved. ... the law he now gives is the subsequent stage in Israel’s developing relationship with God. It is what is expected of a people already redeemed... the people do not earn their salvation but once saved, they are obliged to act in a manner worthy of their high calling...”

Big problem—this explanation doesn’t do justice to the clear “conditional” language... E.g. OK-- while it is true that the OC does not teach that a person is saved by works of the law in the NC sense of forgiveness of sin and eternal life... THIS PASSAGE IS addressing something that is conditional.. **what is it?**

E.g. in what sense is Israel here to be Holy and priestly nation?

Is it in the spiritual and eternal sense or something else... ?

Considering what laws will follow chapter 19 we find that there IS a relationship between obedience and promise—but promises as concerning Israel as a nation within a geographical and political context.

E.g Relationship to Works in the Old and Promise:

T. David Gordon

The Sinai Relation: God instituted a particular covenant at Mount Sinai. As part of that covenant, God instituted a special relation between obedience on the one hand, and temporal prosperity in the land of Canaan, on the other hand.

1. “Honor your father and your mother, that your days may be long in the land which the Lord your God gives you.”
4. “And if you will obey my commandments which I command you this day, to love the Lord your God, and to serve him with all your heart and with all your soul, **he will give rain for your land in its season, the early rain and the later rain, that you may gather in your grain and your wine and your oil.** And he will give grass in your fields for your cattle, and you shall eat and be full. Take heed lest your heart be deceived, and you turn aside and serve other gods and worship them, and the anger of the Lord be kindled against you, and he shut up the heavens, so that there be no rain, and **the land yield no fruit, and you perish quickly off the good land which the Lord gives you....** Behold, I set before you this day a blessing and a curse: the blessing, if you obey the commandments of the Lord your God, which I command you this day, and the curse, if you do not obey the commandments of the Lord your God, but turn aside from the way which I command you this day” (Dt. 11:13-17, 26-28).

E.g. clearly, the “salvation” (if we use this term at all) is a temporal one as set within a conditional context!!!

(say this again)

the Mosaic law, in its immediate and literal context as pertaining to geo-political blessings and curses—is predicated upon a works principle.

As such the Mosaic Law includes all of the stipulations given to Israel through Moses, founded on the "Do this and live" principle, accompanied by the threat of the curse for those who transgress the Law. The sanctions of the Law (blessing and curse) cannot be separated from the stipulations of the Law because the two are inextricably intertwined. Irons

This means that something is about to happen here that is more akin to the conditional nature of things in the establishment of Eden, wherein “do this and live” meant, live in the promised land of Eden..

E.g. The OC law is in many ways a mirror of the original contract established with Adam as predicated upon a works-righteousness principle in order to gain/lose the benefits. The benefits gained or lost are clearly related to the acquisition of land and various geo-political blessings and curses... There is, in this sense, something about the law that is “outward”

PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER:

Our passage in relation to Israel’s history:

- ✓ Yes, we must do justice to this language and call it what it is—a conditional promise.
- ✓ Israel would fail in the promise to “do everything” even as they would fail to fully enter into that “happy rest” that God promised them in a promised land

WE are brought to the place via Israel’s constant failure to live according to the law, and their subsequent experience of the curses attached to this-- wherein we see our inability to keep the law of God in order to sustain God’s justice as predicated upon his holy standards..

The external code of the Law was unable to produce righteousness, and in fact only stirred up sin and brought forth death (Rom. 7:5, 8-10; 2 Cor. 3:6 Iron’s

- ✓ What thn is being referred to here is NOT eternal life but temporal life in a specific place on earth in the middle East, even if it was meant to direct all of history to yet another Israel of God who would be obedient and therefore secure an eternal life for all those who belong to him...

Two things happening at once in the OC:

The distinction between the operation of the works-principle at the typological level and the underlying, foundational promises of grace, at another level:

As then noted by Iron:

By distinguishing these two levels - the typal kingdom of the Israelite theocracy in the land, and the antitypal eternal kingdom of salvation ... the works-principle applied only to the former, which was "superimposed as a secondary overlay" on the foundational stratum of the Abrahamic promise,

through which alone the eternal kingdom of salvation was attained by the elect within Israel.

IN relationship then to the NC:

- ✓ The NC is taught as a CONTRAST” to the Mosaic Covenant, even if in continuity to the Abrahamic covenant

Romans 7:6 But now we are discharged from the law, dead to that which held us captive, so that we are slaves not under the old written code but in the new life of the Spirit.

Heb. 9:15

For this reason he is the mediator of a new covenant, so that those who are called may receive the promised eternal inheritance

- ✓ Therefore, the NC, in continuity with the Abrahamic covenant, and in discontinuity with the works oriented nature of the Mosaic covenant as related to temporal blessings and curses—is a covenant of grace by faith alone!

Eph. 2:8 For by grace you have been saved through faith, and this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God— 9 not the result of works, so that no one may boast.

- ✓ The Mosaic covenant doesn’t annul the Abrahamic covenant, but rather tutor’s the chosen people to faith as to participate in this—it works like this:

Gal. 3:23

Now before faith came, we were imprisoned and guarded under the law until faith would be revealed. 24 Therefore the law was our disciplinarian until Christ came, so that we might be justified by faith. 25 But now that faith has come, we are no longer subject to a disciplinarian, 26 for in Christ Jesus you are all children of God through faith. 27 As many of you as were baptized into Christ have clothed yourselves with Christ. 28 There is no longer Jew or Greek, there is no longer slave or free, there is no longer male and female; for all of you are one in Christ Jesus. 29 And if you belong to Christ, then you are Abraham’s offspring, heirs according to the promise.

E.g. The law acted for humanity as a disciplinarian of sorts—in so far as it disciplines us to our sin and the consequences of our sin as ultimately felt in death—in this sense, we are set free from the law of sin and death according to Paul by faith in Christ! (Gal.3:23ff)

The works principle in the Mosaic Covenant was not given so that the Israelites might achieve eternal life by it - the path to life via works being forever closed off to sinners after the fall - but that God's people might despair of achieving eternal life by their own works, and thus be "shut up" to faith in Christ as the only way of attaining justification and eternal life. As Paul teaches, the Law came 430 years after the Abrahamic Promise, and it was added in order to bring about covenant transgressions, thus functioning as a disciplinarian to lead God's people to Christ. The Law is therefore a parenthesis in the plan of God, and one that is not at odds with the gracious purposes of the Promise, for the Law was subservient to the Promise. Irons

E.g. In this sense, the law directs us to Christ in so far as it directs us to Christ works as the second Adam and second Israel of God—acting on behalf of God’s chosen people to both satisfy the righteousness of the law and to expire the curse of the law upon himself. (Active and passive obedience)

We are schooled in the vicarious nature of the promise given to Abraham of being saved by grace through faith alone—

Believers have been set free from the Law by means of their union with Christ in his death. The Law has jurisdiction over a person only as long as he is alive (Rom. 7:1; Gal. 2:19). Because we have died with Christ, we are "not under law" (Rom. 6:14-15; 7:4-6; 1 Cor. 9:20; Gal. 3:23-25; 4:4-5, 21; 5:18). This means we are free from its condemnation and from its commanding authority. Iron's

E.g. Likewise, and at the same time-- Through the sacrificial system, and one's faith in this system as it ultimately directed us to Christ's sacrificial life of atonement for our sins on the cross. The OC law functions to discipline us to the promise of grace that was given to Adam and restated to the patriarchs, especially Abraham. There is subsequently a "grace-righteousness" principle as well that is enunciated within the Law, albeit in shadows as compared to the fuller enunciation that will come in Christ. As Paul would argue later, the law does not annul the promises to Abraham, but brings us to the promise via its sacrificial system especially.

In sum, we can say that the MOSAIC COVENANT

The covenant at Sinai is God's plan to restore his blessing to mankind through the descendants of Abraham (Gen 12:1-3; Exod 2:24).

- ✓ Therefore, while the promise is that Israel will become a "treasured possession, a kingdom of priests, and a holy nation"—these promises are NEVER fully realized temporally as conditioned upon Israel's obedience, even as they ARE fully realized spiritually and eternally as conditioned upon Christ's obedience!

The New Covenant Relation of works to promise: There is no longer a holy land or a holy people (at least not in the geo-political sense; the church is both international and intra-national), and there are no special covenant blessings/cursings related to temporal prosperity in a given land. In fact, following the example of Christ and the apostles, there appears to be, if anything, an inverse relation between faithfulness and temporal prosperity. Saints in the New Covenant "fill up what is lacking in the sufferings of Christ" (Col 1:24), they intend to know Christ, not only in the power of his resurrection, but also "in the fellowship of his suffering, becoming like him in his death" (Phil. 3:10).

And yet, this suffering is put into the context of having already been granted forgiveness of sins UNCONDITIONALLY and having already been granted eternal life in perfect happiness in the ultimate promised land of a new heavens and new earth of heaven!

Heb. 10:1

Since the law has only a shadow of the good things to come and not the true form of these realities,

Now...

22 let us approach with a true heart in full assurance of faith (vs. of obedience), with our hearts sprinkled clean from an evil conscience and our bodies washed with pure water. 23 Let us hold fast to the confession of our hope without wavering, for he who has promised is faithful.

E.g. Unconditional Forgiveness!

Heb. 11:1

Now faith is the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen. 2 Indeed, by faith our ancestors received approval.

10 For he looked forward to the city that has foundations, **whose architect and builder is God.**

16 But as it is, they desire a better country, that is, a heavenly one. Therefore God is not ashamed to be called their God; indeed, he has prepared a city for them.^a

E.g. Unconditional eternal life in a promised land without geographical bounds except in so far as to include the whole new world...

- ✓ Even as Israel would NOT be obedient to God and be granted the full extent of the promises given, We know that in the coming of Christ, came the truly faithful "Israel of God" even as God would once and for all establish a kingdom of priest unto God as conditioned upon the obedience of Christ and received by faith alone! (1Peter)

1Pet. 2:9

But you are a chosen race, a **royal priesthood**, a holy nation, God's own people, in order that you may proclaim the mighty acts of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light.

Rom. 15:16

to be a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles in the **priestly** service of the gospel of God, so that the offering of the Gentiles may be acceptable, sanctified by the Holy Spirit.

Application: On Eagles Wings!

We should consider then how we ARE carried by God, as on eagles wings as fulfilled in Christ!

- 1) IF the law, coupled with God's providence in our life, has any effect upon us at all, it ought to bring us to consider our weakness as compared to a young eagle trying ever so disparagingly to fly, such as then to require the great wings of its mother to save it from sure destruction!

To be sure, there is perhaps no more nurturing metaphor in all of nature than that metaphor provided by the mothering bird, not least of which the mothering eagle...

We see in the metaphor—a mother patiently and carefully weaving together a bed for the soon to be laid eggs—tirelessly and methodically taking great care in creating the perfect environment into which her blessed chicks can be hatched...

So it was in the creation of God's own image in Eden—as into the hospitality of God himself in a nest perfectly suited to our existence

But of course, the whole thing is done not that the newborn eagles may remain in the nest, but that they might be nurtured to their glorious destiny in flight, soaring above the tumultuous terrain below, as if angelic hosts themselves.

In such manner, God gives birth to a treasured people as by his own creation, he nestles them into a perfect environment, albeit an environment meant to bring them to their glorious destiny of becoming a royal and priestly nation--

But the metaphor takes upon an expanded meaning in the history of that people—for just as the fledgling eagle flaps its new wings, dreaming of the sky—it springs forth out of the nest only to flap about in vain, falling every so clumsily to the ground—

Such is the ingenuity of humanity, seeking to fly on its own—destined to fall by her inability to satisfy the glorious conditions of its very existence.. THE FALL, BABEL, ONE AND ON IT GOES—THE “FLAPPING” OF HUMANITY ONLY TO DISCOVER ITS CLUMSINESS IN SIN APART FROM GOD...

But then it happens, even as the bird flutters down to earth, the great wings of the mature eagle swoops down and saves it from destruction—enabling it to fly another day...

This is depicted by the history of Israel in an outward manner, even as God saves Israel from destruction at the hands of Egypt, even as it foreshadows the ultimate salvation from everlasting condemnation and death as by the wings of God revealed in Jesus Christ.

And if this metaphor can be applied to humanity in the abstract, it can and ought to be applied to each one of us in the subjective as well.

Taking then our cue from the apostle Paul in Roman 7ff, we can identify our own struggles with the struggles of Israel...

Perhaps it was in our attempt to fly in the accomplishment of a marriage, only to discover our clumsy sins, or the attempt to fly in the accomplishment of a vocational goal, only to discover our inability to accomplish our goal, or in the attempt at being good enough to rid ourselves of the fear of condemnation and guilt—only to discover that no matter how much we want to fly in righteousness, we fail in our sins...

And as we are tempted then to despair—crying out as Paul did “Oh wretched man that I am, who is to save me from the body of sin and death”

Then, you are now more than ever conditioned to recognize your need of a savior, and God sweeps down with his might, as like the mighty wings of an eagle, in the salvation accomplished for you by Christ... you discover that your only requirement is to remain perched upon the wings of your savior, as the young eagle to its mother—and you upon Christ begin to soar—up an up, until finally, at the end of your lesson, you are launched into soaring yourself as we all will discover in eternal life and glory

And if then you have learned anything at all from this sacred metaphor—you will learn that we are now more akin to the fledgling young eagle than the mature eagle we all long to be...

Do not then be surprised when you discover, and rediscover again your weakness. Do not be surprised when life is disappointing, when you see in yourself the decay of growing old, or the decay of remaining sin which all the more brings you back to resting on Christ rather than seeking to fly on your own..

Illus—there has never been a person saved by grace through faith that was saved out of personal success and accomplishment? E.g. there is no story into the kingdom of God that doesn't include personal failure!

What is your story?

I think of Augustine's confessions, Luther's preface to Romans and Galatians, Edwards Personal resolutions never really realized, one and on it goes—the stories of how people are brought to see their need for "the wings of eagles"

Sanctification is the same way as well- we grow by first discovering our weakness, such that we can then and again die to self and live in Christ.

And we ought not to grow impatient in clinging to Christ—for we are told that this is the season of redemptive history where we are called to walk by faith and not by sight... '

Trans—we will need to over and over again repent of our arrogance and pride, even as we over and over again cling to Christ by faith—with a full assurance that at the right time, we will be able to fly ourselves by sight... in our glorification that awaits us in heaven.

So let me ask you today and plainly.

Have you been confronted with the clumsiness of your sin and weakness? Can you join Israel in remembering your need for a savior and God's faithfulness to carry you as on eagles wings?

Are you yet aware that you're fluttering down to earth in even your best attempts at flying??

Have you come to see the greatness of God's law, even the greatness of God's intended destiny for you—even as you fail God's law and do not measure up to God's glorious destiny on your own...

If not—then in the next few Sundays, we will be considering the glorious aspects of the law—how the law unveils a kind of holy life that is beyond imagination even—as we are then confronted by that law to see our shortcomings in comparison... and our need for a savior.

And in so far as you see the holiness of the law as your destiny, and your shortcoming in comparison to it—you will I think want to cry out—*wretched man that I am, who will set me free-* even as God's answer will be as the eagles wings under you in Christ.

you will not be surprised if God needs to bring you back to this over and over again given our tendency to forget our need of Christ... he will do this by bringing failure into your life perhaps, by exposing your sin to you, that you might all the more appreciate and remember God's faithfulness to you as a mother her young eagles...

And to all—might we consider as well what glorious creatures you are and were made to be—this is not a lesson that is meant to bring you down—but to bring you up—as you see what glorious creatures you are and will be in God’s plan... be encouraged--

In such manner God has weaved into a history such a perfect nest in order to hatch into this world a treasured people... it is a nest filled with promises and conditions so as to bring us to the ultimate promise as conditioned by that which the ultimate mother on our h

Finally, even as the church is not identified as the treasured people of God—we ought then to consider how we might more and more fulfill God’s purpose for us to be a priestly nation..

E.g. The 1 Peter 2 passage

1Pet. 2:9

But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, God’s own people, in order that you may proclaim the mighty acts of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light.

10 Once you were not a people,
but now you are God’s people;
once you had not received mercy,
but now you have received mercy.

Is not interested in making an abstract connection between Israel and the church alone, but for the purpose of making a connection between Israel’s destiny and role as then given to the church

Even as Israel was to be evangelistic as the “salt of the earth” so then the church (mt.5:13ff)

What Israel as a corporate people failed to do, the church is called to do!

We are therefore called to be “Holy” and priestly—both and at the same Time

We speak of this often here—being not “of” the world but “in the world for the world”...

Many will want to talk much about being not of the world—but then will forget the in/for the world.. whereas others will talk much about being in/for but negate the “not of”

THE TWO ARE ESSENTIAL TO ONE ANOTHER..

E.g. True holiness is manifest in love and witness... true love and witness are beautified by holiness..

So for instance, we are to be other worldly even as this otherworldliness is understood and related as to be attractive to the world ultimately..

Otherworldliness means that we can live our lives as to a higher ethical standard, and with otherworldly values—but we can do this without self-righteousness but with confession—because of our otherworld kind of love and the grace that comes with this...

Expand upon this/..

Lord's supper:

The ultimate "priestly " aspect of our mission is here perfectly made visible, in that the church plants into the city a mediatorial presence of Christ as by this set apart table—one that bring Christ into the city and offers the city forgiveness and grace as to be called to a holy life as well.

Heb. 10: 24 For Christ did not enter a sanctuary made by human hands, a mere copy of the true one, but he entered into heaven itself, now to appear in the presence of God on our behalf. **25** Nor was it to offer himself again and again, as the high priest enters the Holy Place year after year with blood that is not his own; **26** for then he would have had to suffer again and again since the foundation of the world. But as it is, he has appeared once for all at the end of the age to remove sin by the sacrifice of himself. **27** And just as it is appointed for mortals to die once, and after that the judgment, **28** so Christ, having been offered once to bear the sins of many, will appear a second time, not to deal with sin, but to save those who are eagerly waiting for him.

Thus the invitation:

Heb. 10:19

Therefore, my friends, since we have confidence to enter the sanctuary by the blood of Jesus, **20** by the new and living way that he opened for us through the curtain (that is, through his flesh), **21** and since we have a great priest over the house of God, **22** let us approach with a true heart in full assurance of faith, with our hearts sprinkled clean from an evil conscience and our bodies washed with pure water. **23** Let us hold fast to the confession of our hope without wavering, for he who has promised is faithful. **24** And let us consider how to provoke one another to love and good deeds, **25** not neglecting to meet together, as is the habit of some, but encouraging one another, and all the more as you see the Day approaching.

Addendum: Notes from Constible on the use of the Mosaic Law

The Mosaic Law had several purposes:

1. To reveal the holiness of God (1 Peter 1:15)
2. To reveal the sinfulness of man (Gal. 3:19)
3. To reveal the standard of holiness required of those in fellowship with God (Ps. 24:3-5)
4. To supervise physical, mental, and spiritual development of redeemed Israelites until they should come to maturity in Christ (Gal. 3:24; Ps. 119:71-72)
5. To be the unifying principle that made the establishment of the nation possible (Exod. 19:5-8; Deut. 5:27-28)
6. To separate Israel from the nations to become a kingdom of priests (Exod. 31:13; 19:5-6)
7. To make provision for forgiveness of sins and restoration to fellowship (Lev. 1–7)
8. To make provision for a redeemed people to worship (Lev. 23)
9. To provide a test whether one was in the kingdom (theocracy) over which God ruled (Deut. 28)
10. To reveal Jesus Christ.

A movement that is gaining followers in our day, especially among charismatic evangelicals, is the Christian Reconstruction movement, also known as the theonomy movement and the Chalcedon school. Its central thesis is that God intended the Mosaic Law to be normative for all people for all time. Its advocates look forward to a day when Christians will govern everyone using the Old Testament as the law book. Reconstructionism rests on three foundational points: presuppositional apologetics, theonomy (lit. the rule of God), and postmillennialism. This movement is too complex to discuss briefly here, but it is too significant to pass over without mention."

"The covenant with Israel at Sinai is to bring Israel into a position of mediatorial service." Eugene H. Merrill, "The Mosaic Covenant: A Proposal for Its Theological Significance," *Exegesis and Exposition* 3:1 (Fall 1988):29.)

In contrast to the other covenants, the Mosaic covenant, though it had provisions for grace and forgiveness, nevertheless builds on the idea that obedience to God is necessary for blessing. While this to some extent is true in every dispensation, the Mosaic covenant was basically a works covenant rather than a grace covenant. The works principle, however, was limited to the matter of blessing in this life and was not related at all to the question of salvation for eternity."

(John F. Walvoord, "The New Covenant," in *Integrity of Heart, Skillfulness of Hands*, pp. 191-92.)